

Developing a Child Safety Commitment Statement

This document has been developed to assist your organisation to develop a Child Safety Commitment Statement.

It should be used in conjunction with other available resources such as that available from the New South Wales (NSW) Office of Children Guardian, Victorian Commissioner for Children and Young People and the Commonwealth government National Office for Child Safety.

Part One

Q1: Are you required to comply with the Child Safe Standards?

Q2: If you are not required to comply with the Child Safe Standards should you seek to comply to protect the integrity and reputation of your organisation?

Q3: What type of organisations are you i.e. sporting, transport, education, religious, amusement, out of home care etc

Q4: What existing overarching documents do you have which state what your purpose is?

Refer to Strategic Plans, Annual Plans, Business Plan, Marketing, Websites content

Q5: Are you a member of an Association and what documentation may be available which may assist you develop a Child Safety Commitment Statement?

Q6: What process will you use to develop this?

Remember this Statement reflects who your organisation currently is and aspires to be. Be what you are and not what you are not.

Part Two (Developing a Commitment Statement)

When developing key organisational documentation a common mistake authors make is not undertaking appropriate preparation.

The words in the document are important and they **MUST** reflect and be able to be achieved and maintained by your organisation.

Engagement with key stakeholders is important as the Child Safety Commitment Statement should reflect the views of many, such as a Committee.

The table below may assist your preparation. It may be useful to complete this exercise as a group or individually and compare responses.

List your organisations key functions	List how your organisation interacts with children and young persons
State your top five (5) child safety risks based on what your organisation does	State 5 child safe challenges your organisation has with members, participants etc
What expectations do your members have about child Safety?	What expectations does any association or governing body have about child Safety?

Table 1 The Brainstorming Process

Part Three The parts of a Child Safety Commitment Statement

The suggested parts are outlined below with a brief explanation of each area. The Statement should use the public template that your organisation utilises for key Policies.

A Child Safety Policy is different to a Child Safety Commitment Statement. The Commitment Statement public commits your organisation to follow and embed child safe approaches. In contrast the Child Safety Policy outlines how this is achieved.

It is recommended these Policies are not combined so as to not complicate your organisations messaging.

Section	Description
Title	States the title. Examples include Child Safety Commitment Policy
First paragraph	States clearly your commitment to the safety of children and young persons (remember these are two different groups of persons), safeguarding their interests and promoting the dignity and rights of these persons, including the vulnerable. This does not state how you achieve this. Remember these will be outlined in other Policies etc.
Second paragraph	States you have zero tolerance for child abuse. Note this should not solely focus on sexual abuse as there are various type of abuse. Further systems are utilised to respond to and report allegations in a timely manner.
Third Paragraph	Refers specifically to vulnerable persons and states that an organisation seeks to recognise and respond to children and young persons vulnerability in a respectful and caring manner. This can also recognise aspects such as the cultural safety of Aboriginal children, the cultural safety of children from culturally and/or linguistically diverse backgrounds, and to providing a safe environment for children with a disability.
Fourth paragraph	Where there has been previous failings this may be recognised broadly.
Fifth paragraph	There are various ways to now specify what is committed to however the use of short statements (such as in bullet form) can be effective. Key commitments should be as follows: - A commitment to a culture of safeguarding where children and young persons are happy, safe and feel empowered - A commitment to comply with legal requirements. These can be listed briefly - A commitment to those who care for children and young persons being committed to protecting the rights of children and young persons in their care - A commitment to listen to the voice of children and young persons and utilise approaches to assist them to be heard, as well as ensuring they feel empowered

Section	Description
	- A commitment that the organisations leaders understand and oversight the safeguarding in the organisations - A commitment to provide relevant persons with appropriate training in key safeguarding areas - A commitment to have Policies and Procedures which give effect to the approach to safeguarding - The use of a risk based approach to manage safeguarding responsibilities - A commitment to utilise a complaints system which allows persons to raise concerns, be supported and which ensures a consistent process is followed to manage complaints - A culture of reporting as required in a timely manner to appropriate organisations - A commitment to utilise appropriate employment process to screen , interview and employ staff - A commitment to create a safe physical and online environment which is appropriately oversighted - A commitment to comply with Privacy requirements, as required at law such as that relating to personal identifiers and information
Six	States you maintain appropriate records, as required by law which are appropriately stored and retain in accordance with legal requirements.
Seven	States that you review your child safety and approach on a regular basis such as each 18 -24 months.